

Core Meaning - Quick Study Guide

Five reading skills that help you answer one basic question: What does this text actually mean?

Use this guide when: you are unsure whether a question is asking for a fact, the big idea, a supporting detail, a summary, or a theme.

The five skills

Skill	Ask yourself
Explicit meaning	What does the text state directly?
Main idea	What is the whole text mostly about?
Supporting details	Which detail proves or develops the main idea?
Summary	What are the most important ideas, without extra detail?
Theme	What broader message does the literary text suggest?

1. Explicit meaning

This is the most direct kind of reading question. The answer is stated in the text. You do not need to guess what the writer might mean.

What to do

1. Find the key words in the question. 2. Scan for the same idea in the passage. 3. Choose the answer that matches what the passage actually says.

Watch for: An answer can sound reasonable but still be wrong if the text never states it.

Mini example

Text: The library closes at 8 p.m. on weekdays.

Question: When does the library close on Tuesday?

Answer: 8 p.m. The information is stated directly.

2. Main idea

The main idea is the central point that connects the whole passage. It is broader than one detail but narrower than a vague topic.

What to do

1. Ask what most of the passage is doing. 2. Notice repeated ideas. 3. Check whether your answer covers the beginning, middle, and end.

Watch for: Too narrow = one detail. Too broad = a general topic that says almost nothing about this specific passage.

Mini example

Passage: A neighborhood turned an empty lot into a community garden. Residents now grow vegetables, teach children, and share produce.

Main idea: The garden turned unused space into a shared community resource.

3. Supporting details

Supporting details explain, prove, or develop the main idea. A detail can appear in the passage without being useful support for the idea in the question.

What to do

1. Identify the claim or main idea first. 2. Ask what each detail proves. 3. Choose the detail with the strongest direct connection.

Watch for: Do not choose a detail only because it is memorable or repeated.

Mini example

Main idea: The new bus route made commuting easier.

Strong support: Average travel time dropped from 48 minutes to 31 minutes.

That detail directly shows the commute became easier.

4. Summary

A good summary keeps the central idea and the most important supporting points. It leaves out minor examples, opinions, and repeated information.

What to do

1. Find the main idea. 2. Keep only the details needed to understand it. 3. Remove examples that do not change the overall meaning.

Watch for: A summary is not a copy of the passage, and it should not introduce new information.

Mini example

Too detailed: lists every event in order.

Better: explains the problem, the main response, and the result in a few sentences.

5. Theme

Theme is a broader message suggested by a literary text. It is usually expressed as an idea about people, choices, relationships, or life - not as one word.

What to do

1. Notice the character's conflict. 2. Look at choices and consequences. 3. State the message as a complete idea that fits the whole story.

Watch for: A topic such as "friendship" is not yet a theme. A theme might be "trust grows when people are willing to be honest."

Mini example

Story pattern: A student hides a mistake, then admits it and receives help.

Possible theme: Admitting a mistake can be the first step toward solving it.

Fast decision checklist

When a question feels confusing, identify the job first.

If the question asks...	Think...
According to the passage / what happened / what does X say?	Explicit meaning
Mostly about / central idea / main point	Main idea
Best supports / which detail shows	Supporting details
Best summary / best restates	Summary
Message / lesson / theme	Theme

One rule that helps everywhere: choose the answer that is supported by the text, not the answer that sounds nicest or matches what you already believe.

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